Comp vs. Hours: What Each Seat Actually Pays You Per Hour

All-in first-year compensation for a typical strong performer at a strong shop, against a realistic weekly hour load. The dollars-per-hour column is the number nobody puts on the recruiting slide.

Role	All-In Comp	Hours / Wk	~ $ / Hour
IB Analyst	$180k	90	**~$40**
Sales & Trading	$160k	55	**~$58**
PE Associate	$350k	75	**~$93**
Private Credit Assoc.	$300k	55	**~$109**
Hedge Fund Analyst	$400k	60	**~$133**

What You Are Buying With Those Hours

IB Analyst The training tax. Lowest effective rate on the street because the hours are uncapped, but it remains the widest-optionality seat: PE, credit, hedge funds and corporates all recruit out of it.

Sales & Trading Better hours from day one and a real life outside the desk. Comp is more bonus-levered and career paths are narrower. Exits skew to other trading seats, not the broad buyside.

PE Associate Big step up in comp, modest step down in hours. Deal sprints still produce banking weeks, and the work is process-heavy: diligence, models, memos, sponsors.

Private Credit Assoc. The efficiency play. Near-PE comp on S&T hours because credit deals close faster and carry less pageantry. Underwriting focus: cash flows, leverage, covenants, downside cases.

Hedge Fund Analyst Highest rate on the board and the highest variance. Comp is tied to your ideas and the fund's year, tenure is fragile, and there is no process to hide behind.

The takeaway: rank seats by $/hour and optionality, not by headline comp.

Take the 60-second quiz and get a personalized path to the seat with the best rate for your profile.

TAKE THE QUIZ → wallstalpha.com/apply

Figures are illustrative first-year all-in estimates (base + bonus) for competitive U.S. platforms and vary widely by firm, group, city and year. Hours are typical, not guaranteed. Educational only; verify with firms directly.